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HAS IT WORKED? Ravi and Navneet Rana after their arrest in Mumbai

MUMBAI

An Unholy Controversy

By Kiran D. Tare

One cannot say to what degree he is behind the weaponisation of one of Hinduism's plainest practices—the recitation of the Hanuman Chalisa—but Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief Raj Thackeray's thunder was stolen, and how! After Thackeray on April 12 warned of reciting the Chalisa in front of mosques to stop loudspeakers from being used for *azaan* and other announcements, independent MLA Ravi Rana announced on April 17 that he would recite it outside the residence of Maharashtra chief minister Uddhav Thackeray. It was not taken seriously.

Rana, who represents Badnera in Amravati district, reached Mumbai on April 22 along with wife Navneet, the Lok Sabha MP from Amravati. Although the duo announced they had given up their plan, angry Shiv Sena workers gathered outside their Mumbai home the next day and filed a complaint against them for 'inciting violence'. Acting swiftly, the Mumbai Police arrested the couple the same night for "promoting enmity between different religions" and sedition.

Rana had claimed that his plans were meant to goad Uddhav into reciting the Chalisa. "I want the CM to recite it, seeking the deity's blessings.... He is not doing it. That is why I want to take responsibility," he had told INDIA TODAY in a brief interview.

The Ranas are at loggerheads with the Sena in Amravati, around 650 km east of Mumbai. Ever since he first won from Badnera in 2009, Ravi Rana has been known for backing any party that suits his needs. But he is popular among the youth and enjoys the backing of yoga guru Baba Ramdev. Ramdev also played match-maker for him and Navneet, a small-time actor born into a Punjabi family in Mumbai.

Rana had launched a fiery attack on the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) before the 2014 Lok Sabha election. However, an LS ticket for Navneet from the Nationalist Congress Party was procured. She lost to the Sena's Anand Adsul in Amravati. In October 2014, after the BJP came to power in Maharashtra, Rana switched his support to it. In the 2019 LS poll, Navneet contested as an independent with NCP support and defeated Adsul. Rana announced support for the BJP that October when it emerged as the single largest party after the assembly poll, but stated he was 'neutral' when the Sena broke away and formed the government with the NCP and Congress in November.

OBSERVERS SAY BY THE HANUMAN CHALISA PLAN, THE RANAS HOPE TO COSY UP TO THE BJP AGAIN

Political observers believe the Ranas' Hanuman Chalisa plan is an attempt to cosy up to the BJP again. Navneet had drawn flak in 2019 when she said that 'Jai Shri Ram' chants must not be raised in Parliament. The BJP initially ignored the Ranas, but supported them after their arrest, denouncing the attacks on BJP leader Kirit Somaiya by Sena workers when he visited the duo in jail. Leader of the opposition Devendra Fadnavis alleged a "breakdown in law and order" and said "democracy is being trampled in Maharashtra".

In these remarks, Maharashtra civil supplies minister Chhagan Bhujbal smelt a conspiracy to impose president's rule. Fadnavis denied it, saying, "We will return to power with a thumping majority." The BJP believes the Ranas could help it dent the Sena's image. "They have no followers in Mumbai but succeeded in pushing Uddhav Thackeray on the back foot," says a BJP leader.

Meanwhile, Navneet has written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, alleging that after her arrest, at the Khar police station, she was not provided drinking water, was prevented from using the washroom and was abused on the basis of her low caste (Amravati is a constituency reserved for SCs). Birla has sought details on the matter from Maharashtra.

The CM, ever aware of his softened stand on Hindutva, took a step back. "If you (Ranas) had sought permission for reciting the Hanuman Chalisa at my house, I would have welcomed you," Uddhav said on April 25. "If you show high-handedness, you will get a befitting reply."

It seems Hindutva has lodged itself in the state's politics. The next twist in its tortuous course may come after May 3—the deadline cousin Raj Thackeray has set for removing loudspeakers from mosques. ■